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Essay 1: Views on University English Education in Japan

Early in my time teaching in Japan, a student shared something with me that fundamentally shifted how I view my work: *"When I speak English, I can be a different person."* That statement stayed with me because it pointed to something far deeper than grammar rules or test preparation. It spoke to identity, confidence, and the future learners imagine for themselves through language. It reminded me of a note a Japanese friend left on my fridge after bringing over a small dessert: *"You can eat a whole watermelon anytime!"* Technically, the sentence was inaccurate. But functionally, the meaning was crystal clear, warm, and human. Language at its best is about connection, pragmatic nuance, and taking a chance to express who we are.

For many Japanese university students entering higher education, however, their relationship with English has been shaped primarily by secondary school *yakudoku* (grammar-translation) and entrance exam preparation. While this foundation equips students with strong explicit grammatical knowledge, it often leaves them with a high affective filter and a hesitation to speak for fear of making mistakes. In my view, the central purpose of university English education in Japan is to guide students across the bridge from passive, test-oriented knowledge to active, communicative agency.

To facilitate this transition, my practice is grounded in Bonny Norton's foundational concepts of *investment* and *imagined L2 identities*. Learners do not enter the university classroom merely as empty vessels consuming target language input; they bring their identities, lived experiences, and aspirations for who they want to become. When a student imagines themselves studying abroad, presenting at an international conference, or navigating cross-cultural workplaces, their motivation shifts from external obligation to personal investment.

In my graduate research at the University of Southern Maine, I framed the communicative classroom as a *living ecosystem*: a dynamic environment where trust, risk-taking, and linguistic growth must be thoughtfully built. Academic rigor alone is insufficient if the emotional environment lacks safety. Building relational trust through active teacher listening, constructive feedback, and small moments of genuine encouragement creates the conditions necessary for students to step outside their comfort zones. When students realize the classroom is a judgment-free space designed for trial and discovery, they begin taking the linguistic risks required for genuine fluency.

Practically, this philosophy translates into a task-based, student-centered methodology. Drawing

on my experience teaching intensive university courses at Kindai University and university-bound students at KUAS, I design lessons structured around real-world communication, collaborative problem-solving, and conversational pragmatics. Rather than drilling isolated vocabulary, I focus on how language functions in everyday social interactions, academic discussions, and nuanced cultural contexts. Whether scaffolding academic writing, guiding IELTS preparation, or integrating digital learning tools to explore conversational nuances, the goal remains the same: making English practical, accessible, and deeply relevant to students' lives.

Ultimately, university English education in Japan should not be an exercise in perfectionism, but an invitation to global citizenship. As educators, our role is to demystify the language, build communicative confidence, and support learners as they navigate both academic demands and personal growth. By building an environment rooted in relational pedagogy, task-based engagement, and cultural nuance, we empower Japanese university students to step beyond the fear of error, embrace their English-speaking identities, and connect meaningfully with the wider world.